CURIOUS SPAROOWS · ENCYCLOPEDIC INDEX

COOKING

Did cooking make us human?

World cuisines · India state by state and community by community · the six rasas and the science of taste · ingredients and their journeys · techniques · dish families · dish cards · history · people · awards and GI foods · ideas · health · practical guide

Parts	Sections	Sub-sections	Entries	Register rows
16	43	37	300	107

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How to Use This Booklet

This booklet is a map of the world's cooking: world cuisines, India state by state and community by community, taste, ingredients, techniques, dish families, history, people, awards, ideas, health and a practical guide. Every entry tells you, in one or two lines, what the thing is and why it matters.

Every entry has an ID (such as COK-11.3 for dum cooking). The same ID is the entry's address on curioussparoows.com, where each one is growing into its own page.

How this booklet is organised

Parts: the intro questions, the master map, cuisines, taste, ingredients, techniques, dishes, registers, history, people, ideas, health, the practical guide, reviews, navigation and sources.

Sections (COK-01 to COK-32): the main topics.

Sub-sections and entries (☐): one or two lines each; tick the box when you have cooked or tasted.

Registers: 30 dish cards, the timeline, awards and guides, GI foods and festivals. They are a sourced selection; the full lists grow on the website.

How to explore it

Step 1. Read Part 0, six two-minute questions.

Step 2. Find your own state's cuisine in Part 2.

Step 3. Cook the beginner's 20 dishes in Part 12.

Step 4. Follow tags and See also links to gardening, films and books.

Step 5. Tick ☐ as you cook, and keep a cooking diary.

Our promise

Knowledge belongs to the people who created it. Every fact here stands on a source listed in Part 15, and every "latest" fact says when it was checked. Where something could not be verified, we say so instead of guessing. Found a mistake? Tell us, and we will fix it and thank you.

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PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: DID COOKING MAKE US HUMAN?

About this Part. This is the doorway to the Cooking section of the website, in the tree-twig format of the Curious Sparoons library: one Gateway page, six Leaves and one Recap. Each Leaf answers one question in about two minutes (250 to 400 words), gives its short answer first and ends with a hook to the next question.

COK-00 The Gateway: Did cooking make us human?

Web address: /cooking/did-cooking-make-us-human/ · **Keywords:** history of cooking, world cuisines, Indian cuisine, science of taste, cooking for beginners

No other animal cooks. Chimpanzees chew raw fruit and leaves for about six hours a day; humans eat in an hour or two and spend the rest of the day talking, building and dreaming. The primatologist Richard Wrangham argues that fire and cooking gave us that time and the energy for our large brains. Whether or not he is fully right, every culture on Earth cooks, and every culture believes its food is the best.

This short course asks one question in six steps: **what is cooking, and why does it matter so much to us?** It goes from the first campfires to the chilli's journey from Mexico to Rajasthan, from the science of umami to the memory in grandmother's dal. Each page takes about two minutes.

By the end you will be able to:

- Explain the "cooking hypothesis" and its evidence.
- Say why chilli feels hot when it has no heat.
- Trace the chilli, potato and tomato from the Americas to India.
- Explain why flatbreads appear in almost every culture.
- Name the five basic tastes and tell the story of umami.
- Describe how smell and memory make home food special.

COK-00.01 What did humans eat before fire?

> **Short answer:** Our ancestors ate raw plants (fruits, leaves, roots, nuts, seeds), insects, eggs and some raw or scavenged meat, softened by pounding and cutting with stone tools. Controlled fire appears in the record at least 1 million years ago (Wonderwerk Cave, South Africa), and regular hearths by about 400,000 years ago.

Keywords: what did early humans eat, raw food diet history, discovery of fire, cooking hypothesis, Wrangham Catching Fire

Food before fire

Stone tools are at least 3.3 million years old. Cut marks on animal bones show that early humans sliced meat and broke bones for marrow. Plants were the daily staple: tubers dug from the ground, seeds and fruit.

The cooking hypothesis

In *Catching Fire: How Cooking Made Us Human* (2009), Richard Wrangham argues that cooking began with *Homo erectus*, perhaps 1.8 million years ago. Cooking makes starch and protein easier to digest, kills germs and softens food, so our guts and teeth could shrink while our brains grew.

The debate

Clear evidence of fire that old is rare; many archaeologists think regular cooking came later. Everyone agrees, though, that by the time of modern humans, cooking was universal. No known human society eats only raw food.

> **Remember this:** Cooking may be older than our species, and it changed our bodies.

Next: If cooking is about pleasure, why do we love chilli, which hurts?

COK-00.02 Why do we love spicy food that hurts?

Short answer: Chilli's capsaicin triggers the same pain receptor (TRPV1) that senses real heat, so the brain thinks the mouth is burning. The body releases endorphins, and the psychologist Paul Rozin calls the pleasure "benign masochism": enjoying a thrill we know is safe, like a roller coaster.

Keywords: why is chilli hot, capsaicin, Scoville scale, why we like spicy food, benign masochism

A fake fire

Capsaicin binds to TRPV1, a receptor that normally warns us of temperatures above about 43 °C. David Julius discovered this receptor using capsaicin, work that shared the Nobel Prize in Physiology or Medicine in 2021.

Measuring heat

The **Scoville scale** (Wilbur Scoville, 1912) once used tasters diluting a chilli extract until the heat vanished; today labs measure capsaicin directly. Bell peppers score 0; India's *bhut jolokia* (ghost pepper, from the north-east) passed 1 million Scoville units and was the world's hottest in 2007.

Why spice?

- **Pleasure and thrill** (Rozin).
- **Culture**: children learn to like chilli by eating with family.
- **Food safety**: the biologists Jennifer Billing and Paul Sherman (1998) found spice use is higher in hot countries, and argued spices help fight food spoilage; this idea is debated.

Remember this: Chilli fools the heat sensor; we enjoy the safe danger.

Next: Chilli feels so Indian. How did it reach India from America?

COK-00.03 How did the chilli reach India if it came from America?

Short answer: Chilli was domesticated in Mexico thousands of years ago. After Columbus reached the Americas in 1492, Portuguese traders carried chilli to Goa and the Malabar coast in the early 1500s. Within a century it had spread across India, replacing long pepper and black pepper as the main source of heat.

Keywords: history of chilli in India, Columbian Exchange, Portuguese food India, origin of potato tomato India, foods that came to India

The Columbian Exchange

The historian Alfred Crosby named it the **Columbian Exchange** (1972): the movement of plants, animals and diseases between the Americas and the rest of the world after 1492. From the Americas came chilli, potato, tomato, maize, groundnut, cashew, pineapple, papaya, guava, sweet potato, cocoa and vanilla. From the Old World went wheat, rice, sugarcane, cattle and many spices.

India's "new" foods

- **Chilli**: Goa in the 1500s; the composer-saint Purandara Dasa (16th century) praises it in a Kannada song.
- **Potato**: grown in India by the 17th century, spread widely under British rule.
- **Tomato**: common only from the 19th century.
- **Cashew and pineapple**: Portuguese gifts to Goa and Kerala.

Before chilli

Indian food was hot with black pepper (*Piper nigrum*, native to the Western Ghats), long pepper (*pippali*), ginger and mustard.

Remember this: Many "Indian" ingredients are immigrants; Indian cooks made them their own.

Next: Some foods are found everywhere. Why does every culture have a flatbread?

COK-00.04 Why does every culture have a flatbread?

Short answer: Flatbread is the simplest way to turn ground grain into food: mix flour and water, flatten, and cook on a hot stone, griddle or oven wall. It needs no yeast, little fuel and no oven. Archaeologists found charred flatbread crumbs in Jordan (Shubayqa 1) about 14,400 years old, older than farming.

Keywords: history of bread, flatbread types, roti history, oldest bread, chapati naan tortilla

A world of flatbreads

- **India**: roti, chapati, phulka, paratha, puri, bhakri, naan (oven), thepla, makki ki roti, bajre ki roti, appam and dosa (fermented batter).
- **West Asia**: pita, lavash (UNESCO intangible heritage), markook.
- **The Americas**: corn tortilla, made with nixtamalised maize (soaked in lime), which unlocks niacin.
- **Ethiopia**: injera, a spongy fermented teff bread.
- **Europe**: piadina, lefse, oatcakes; pizza began as a flatbread.
- **China**: bing and scallion pancakes.

Why so many?

- **Simple tools**: a stone or iron griddle (*tawa*, *comal*, *saj*).
- **Fuel-saving**: cooks in a minute or two.
- **Portable**: it travels with herders, soldiers and workers.
- **A plate and spoon**: you scoop with it, so it doubles as cutlery.

Remember this: Flatbread is older than farming and is the world's most shared food idea.

Next: Bread tastes of grain. But what is the savoury taste in broth, cheese and tomato?

COK-00.05 What makes umami?

Short answer: Umami is the savoury taste of glutamate and certain nucleotides (inosinate, guanylate). The Japanese chemist Kikunae Ikeda identified it in 1908 from kombu seaweed broth and named it *umami* ("delicious taste"). Science now accepts five basic tastes: sweet, sour, salty, bitter and umami.

Keywords: what is umami, five basic tastes, MSG, glutamate, kokumi, six rasas

Ikeda's soup

Ikeda wondered why his wife's *dashi* (kombu broth) tasted so rich. He extracted glutamic acid, tasted its salt (monosodium glutamate, MSG) and launched the company Ajinomoto (1909). Taste receptors for umami (T1R1 and T1R3) were identified around 2000 to 2002.

Umami foods

Tomatoes (especially ripe or sun-dried), parmesan, soy sauce, fish sauce, mushrooms, meat broth, aged cheese, and in India dried fish, fermented bamboo shoot and slow-cooked onion-tomato *masala*.

Is MSG harmful?

Food-safety bodies, including the US FDA and the EU's EFSA, consider MSG safe at normal intake; the "Chinese restaurant syndrome" panic of 1968 has not held up in controlled studies. FSSAI requires it to be labelled.

Beyond five

Scientists study **kokumi** (a "richness" sensation), fat taste and others. Ayurveda counts **six rasas**: sweet, sour, salty, pungent, bitter and astringent, which describe effects on the body as well as taste (COK-05).

Remember this: Umami is the taste of savoury depth, named in Japan in 1908.

Next: Taste is only part of the story. Why does grandma's food taste better?

COK-00.06 Why does grandma's food taste better?

Short answer: Flavour is mostly smell, and smell signals travel to the brain's emotional and memory centres (the amygdala and hippocampus) more directly than other senses. So a familiar dish brings back the people, places and feelings around it. Marcel Proust made this famous with a madeleine dipped in tea (1913).

Keywords: food and memory, comfort food psychology, Proust madeleine, smell and memory, why home food tastes better

Smell is flavour

When you chew, aromas rise from the back of the mouth to the nose (retronasal smell). Pinch your nose and a strawberry tastes merely sweet. Taste gives five signals; smell gives thousands.

Memory and emotion

Smell pathways connect closely with the limbic system, which handles emotion and memory. Studies suggest smell-triggered memories feel more vivid and emotional and often come from childhood.

The other ingredients

- **Familiarity**: we come to like what we eat often (the "mere exposure" effect).
- **Care**: knowing someone cooked for you changes how food feels.
- **Skill**: decades of practice; *andaaz*, cooking by eye and hand.
- **Context**: festival, family and home.

Remember this: Grandma's food tastes better because it carries memory, love and smell.

Next: The Recap ties the six questions together.

COK-00.07 Recap: from the first fire to the family table

- **COK-00.01**: Fire and cooking may have shaped our bodies; regular cooking is universal.
- **COK-00.02**: Chilli fools the heat sensor TRPV1; we enjoy the safe thrill.
- **COK-00.03**: Chilli, potato and tomato reached India through the Columbian Exchange.
- **COK-00.04**: Flatbread is older than farming and found everywhere.
- **COK-00.05**: Umami, named by Kikunae Ikeda in 1908, is the fifth basic taste.
- **COK-00.06**: Smell links food with memory and emotion.

Where to go next: the Master Map (Part 1), then your own state's cuisine (Part 2). **Quick quiz:** Which receptor senses capsaicin? Who named umami? Name three foods India got from the Americas.

PART 1 — THE MASTER MAP OF COOKING

About this Part. The whole hierarchy on one page, so every cuisine, ingredient, technique and dish has an address. The website follows the same tree.

COK-01 The hierarchy: from Forest to Leaf

Before you start — COK-01. The Forest is "Cooking". It splits into six Trees: cuisines (where food comes from), taste (how we experience it), ingredients (what it is made of), techniques (how it is cooked), dishes (what it becomes) and the human side (history, people, ideas, health and practice). A dish like biryani appears under its cuisine, its technique (dum) and its family (rice dishes); the website links all three. **See also:** COK-00 (the Gateway).

- ☐ **COK-01.1 Cuisines**: continents, countries, regions; India state by state and community by community (Part 2).
- ☐ **COK-01.2 Taste and flavour**: the six rasas, the five tastes, aroma, texture and heat (Part 3).
- ☐ **COK-01.3 Ingredients**: grains to fermented foods, with their journeys (Part 4).
- ☐ **COK-01.4 Techniques**: knife skills, heat methods, Indian techniques, baking, fermentation and preservation (Part 5).
- ☐ **COK-01.5 Dish families**: breads, rice, curries, soups, snacks, sweets and drinks (Part 6).
- ☐ **COK-01.6 Registers**: dish cards, the timeline, awards and GI foods (Part 7).
- ☐ **COK-01.7 The human side**: history (Part 8), people and awards (Part 9), ideas (Part 10), health and safety (Part 11), the practical guide (Part 12) and reviews (Part 13).

PART 2 — WORLD CUISINES

About this Part. Continent, then country, then region. Each line names the cuisine's core ingredients and signature dishes. "Cuisine" here means a shared style of cooking; within every country there are many home kitchens.

COK-02 Asia (outside India)

Before you start — COK-02. Asia holds over half of humanity and most of the world's rice eaters. Rice, soy, fish sauce, chilli and fresh herbs connect many of its kitchens. **See also:** COK-03 (India).

- ☐ **COK-02.1 China**: eight great regional cuisines, including Sichuan (mala: numbing Sichuan pepper and chilli), Cantonese (dim sum, roast meats, steaming), Shandong, Jiangsu, Zhejiang, Fujian, Hunan and Anhui; the wok, soy and rice or wheat.
- ☐ **COK-02.2 Japan**: *washoku* (UNESCO intangible heritage, 2013): rice, miso soup, dashi, sushi, tempura (a Portuguese gift), ramen, seasonal *kaiseki*.
- ☐ **COK-02.3 Korea**: kimchi and *kimjang* (UNESCO, 2013), bibimbap, gochujang, Korean barbecue, banchan (side dishes).
- ☐ **COK-02.4 Thailand**: balance of sweet, sour, salty and hot; tom yum, green curry, pad thai, som tam.
- ☐ **COK-02.5 Vietnam**: pho, banh mi (French baguette meets Vietnamese fillings), fresh herbs, fish sauce.
- ☐ **COK-02.6 Indonesia and Malaysia**: rendang, nasi goreng, satay, sambal; Malaysia's Malay, Chinese, Indian and Peranakan (Nyonya) blend.
- ☐ **COK-02.7 Philippines**: adobo, sinigang, lechon; Spanish and Chinese layers.
- ☐ **COK-02.8 South Asia beyond India**: Pakistan (nihari, karahi, Peshawari kebabs), Bangladesh (hilsa, bhorta), Sri Lanka (hoppers, kottu, coconut sambols), Nepal (momo, dal bhat, gundruk), Bhutan (ema datshi: chilli and cheese), Maldives (tuna and coconut), Afghanistan (Kabuli pulao, mantu).
- ☐ **COK-02.9 West Asia**: Lebanon and the Levant (hummus, falafel, mezze, tabbouleh), Iran (polo rice with tahdig, khoresh stews, saffron), Turkey (kebabs, meze, baklava, Turkish coffee: UNESCO 2013), the Gulf (machboos), Israel and Palestine (shakshuka, maqluba).
- ☐ **COK-02.10 Central Asia**: plov (UNESCO, Uzbekistan 2016), manti, laghman, nomadic dairy.

COK-03 Europe, Africa, the Americas and Oceania

- ☐ **COK-03.1 France**: the "gastronomic meal of the French" (UNESCO, 2010); mother sauces, bread and pastry, regional cooking from Provence to Normandy; the codifier Auguste Escoffier (COK-21).
- ☐ **COK-03.2 Italy**: regional pasta, pizza (Neapolitan *pizzaiuolo* art: UNESCO 2017), risotto, olive oil, cheese; Italian cooking as a whole was inscribed by UNESCO in December 2025.
- ☐ **COK-03.3 Spain and Portugal**: tapas, paella, jamón; Portugal's bacalhau and pastel de nata; Portuguese sailors spread chilli, bread and vinegar cooking to Goa, Macau and Japan.
- ☐ **COK-03.4 The Mediterranean diet**: UNESCO (2013) for seven countries; much studied for heart health.
- ☐ **COK-03.5 Britain and Ireland**: roasts, pies, fish and chips, afternoon tea; chicken tikka masala as a British-Indian dish.
- ☐ **COK-03.6 Central and Eastern Europe**: German breads and sausages, Austrian pastry, Hungarian paprika (goulash), Polish pierogi, Russian borscht (Ukrainian borscht culture: UNESCO 2022).
- ☐ **COK-03.7 The Nordic countries**: rye bread, smoked and pickled fish, the "New Nordic" movement (Noma, 2003).
- ☐ **COK-03.8 North Africa**: couscous (UNESCO 2020, shared by Algeria, Mauritania, Morocco and Tunisia), tagines, harissa, Egyptian koshari and ful medames.
- ☐ **COK-03.9 West Africa**: jollof rice (friendly rivalry between Nigeria and Ghana), fufu, egusi soup, suya.
- ☐ **COK-03.10 East and Southern Africa**: Ethiopian injera and wat with berbere; Kenyan ugali and nyama choma; South African braai, bobotie and the Durban bunny chow (Indian roots).
- ☐ **COK-03.11 North America**: US regional food (barbecue, Cajun and Creole, Tex-Mex, soul food), Native American foods (maize, beans, squash), Canada's poutine.
- ☐ **COK-03.12 Mexico**: traditional Mexican cuisine (UNESCO, 2010): maize and nixtamal, tortillas, mole, tacos, chilli varieties.
- ☐ **COK-03.13 The Caribbean**: jerk, rice and peas; Trinidad's roti and doubles from Indian indentured workers.

☐ **COK-03.14 South America**: Peru (ceviche, potatoes, Nikkei and Chifa fusions; Lima's restaurants top world lists), Brazil (feijoada, açaí), Argentina (asado), Colombia (arepas).

☐ **COK-03.15 Oceania**: Australian bush foods and modern Australian cooking; Māori hāngī (earth oven); Pacific island taro, coconut and fish.

COK-04 India: the many cuisines of one country

Before you start — COK-04. "Indian food" is really dozens of cuisines shaped by climate, crops, religion, trade and history. A simple map: wheat and dairy in the north-west, rice and fish in the east and coast, millets and pulses in the dry interior, coconut in the south. Mustard oil, groundnut oil, sesame oil, coconut oil and ghee divide the country almost as much as language. K. T. Achaya's *Indian Food: A Historical Companion* (1994) is the standard history.

☐ COK-04.1 North and North-West India

☐ **COK-04.1a Rajasthani and Marwari**: food for a desert: dal-baati-churma, gatte ki sabzi, ker sangri, bajre ki roti, laal maas (Mewar), mirchi vada, ghevar; long-keeping foods with little water and much ghee. Marwari trading families carried their vegetarian cooking across India.

☐ **COK-04.1b Punjabi**: tandoor breads, sarson da saag with makki di roti, rajma, chole, dal makhani and butter chicken (popularised by Delhi's Moti Mahal after 1947; who invented it is now disputed in court), lassi.

☐ **COK-04.1c Kashmiri**: *Wazwan*, a multi-course Muslim feast cooked by *wazas* (rista, gushtaba, rogan josh); Kashmiri Pandit cooking with yoghurt, fennel, dry ginger and asafoetida, no onion or garlic; kahwa tea.

☐ **COK-04.1d Himachali and Pahari**: *dham* (festive feast), siddu, Garhwali and Kumaoni food (kafuli, bhatt ki churkani, mandua roti).

☐ **COK-04.1e Awadhi**: the Lucknow court cuisine: dum pukht (slow, sealed cooking), galouti kebab, nihari, sheermal, biryani in the *pakki* style.

☐ **COK-04.1f Mughlai**: Mughal court food: kormas, pulao, kebabs, rich gravies with nuts and cream, Persian and Central Asian roots.

☐ **COK-04.1g Delhi and Old Delhi street food**: chaat, parathe wali gali, kebabs of Jama Masjid.

☐ **COK-04.1h Uttar Pradesh and Bihar**: litti chokha, sattu, Banarasi chaat and paan, thekua, Mathura peda.

☐ COK-04.2 East and North-East India

☐ **COK-04.2a Bengali**: rice and fish (*maachh-bhaat*), mustard oil, panch phoron; shukto, machher jhol, chingri malai curry, mishti doi, rosogolla, sandesh; a formal order of courses from bitter to sweet.

☐ **COK-04.2b Odia**: dalma, pakhala (fermented rice water), chhena poda, temple food of Puri (*mahaprasad*); rasagola (GI, 2019).

☐ **COK-04.2c Assamese**: khar (alkaline dishes), masor tenga (sour fish), pitha, bamboo shoot, joha rice.

☐ **COK-04.2d The north-eastern states**: Naga smoked pork and bhut jolokia; Manipuri eromba and black rice (chak-hao); Meghalaya's jadoh; Mizo bai; Sikkimese momos and gundruk; Arunachal's apong (rice beer); Tripura's berma (fermented fish).

☐ **COK-04.2e Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh and tribal cuisines**: mahua, red-ant chutney (*chapda*, Odisha and Chhattisgarh; GI for Similipal kai chutney, 2024), millets, forest greens, rice beer (*handia*).

☐ COK-04.3 West India

☐ **COK-04.3a Gujarati**: a sweet, sour and salty balance; the Gujarati thali, dhokla, thepla, undhiyu, khandvi, kadhi; Kathiawadi food is spicier.

☐ **COK-04.3b Maharashtrian**: varan bhaat, puran poli, misal pav, vada pav (Mumbai, 1960s), Kolhapuri mutton, Malvani seafood, modak.

☐ **COK-04.3c Goan**: Hindu Saraswat and Catholic traditions; fish curry rice, xacuti, vindaloo (from Portuguese *carne de vinha d'alhos*), sorpotel, bebinca, feni.

☐ **COK-04.3d Konkani and Mangalorean**: coconut, kokum and seafood; neer dosa, kori rotti, Mangalorean Catholic pork bafat.

☐ **COK-04.3e Parsi**: from Iranian Zoroastrian migrants: dhansak, patra ni machhi, salli boti, lagan nu custard, akuri; Irani cafés of Mumbai and Pune.

☐ **COK-04.3f Sindhi**: sai bhaji, Sindhi kadhi, koki, dal pakwan; carried to India after 1947.

☐ COK-04.4 South India

☐ **COK-04.4a Tamil and Chettinad**: sambar, rasam, idli and dosa, pongal; Chettinad's fiery pepper, star anise and kalpasi (stone flower) dishes; banana-leaf meals.

☐ **COK-04.4b Udupi**: temple-linked vegetarian cooking of coastal Karnataka; masala dosa and the Udupi restaurant chains that spread South Indian food across India.

☐ **COK-04.4c Karnataka beyond Udupi**: bisi bele bath, ragi mudde, Mysore pak, Kodava pandi curry, Mangalore buns.

☐ **COK-04.4d Kerala**: coconut and coconut oil, appam and stew, puttu and kadala, karimeen pollichathu, Malabar (Moplah) biryani, Syrian Christian cooking, *sadya* on Onam.

☐ **COK-04.4e Andhra and Telangana**: famous for heat: gongura pickle, pesarattu, pulihora; Hyderabadi biryani (*kacchi* style), haleem (GI, 2010), double ka meetha.

☐ **COK-04.4f Hyderabadi**: the Nizams' Deccani court cuisine, mixing Mughlai, Persian, Turkish and Telugu flavours.

☐ COK-04.5 Community, faith and history kitchens

☐ **COK-04.5a Jain food**: no root vegetables (to spare tiny life in the soil), no onion or garlic, eating before sunset; ingenious use of raw banana, dried vegetables and spices.

☐ **COK-04.5b Satvik food**: fresh, light, vegetarian food linked with yoga and Ayurveda; no onion, garlic or stale food.

☐ **COK-04.5c Temple food**: *prasad* and temple kitchens: Puri Jagannath's *mahaprasad*, Tirupati laddu (GI, 2009), Golden Temple's *langar* (feeding tens of thousands every day), Udupi Krishna Matha.

☐ **COK-04.5d Anglo-Indian**: railway mutton curry, mulligatawny, jalfrezi, pepper water, "country captain"; a blend of British and Indian kitchens.

☐ **COK-04.5e Indian-Chinese**: Kolkata's Tangra Hakka community gave India chilli chicken and hakka noodles; chicken manchurian is credited to Nelson Wang (Mumbai, 1975), and gobi manchurian is its vegetarian child.

☐ **COK-04.5f Muslim community cuisines**: Bohri thaal, Memon, Moplah, Kutchi Memon, Bhopali and Rampuri kitchens.

☐ **COK-04.5g Jewish communities**: Bene Israel, Cochin and Baghdadi Jewish food (chitarnee, aloo makala).

☐ **COK-04.5h Tribal and forest food**: millets, wild greens, mushrooms, insects, smoked meats and rice beers; the knowledge of Adivasi communities, often unrecorded.

☐ **COK-04.5i Indian diaspora food**: Durban, Trinidad, Fiji, Mauritius, Malaysia and the British curry house.

PART 3 — TASTE, FLAVOUR AND THE SCIENCE OF EATING

About this Part. How we experience food, in two languages: Ayurveda's six rasas and modern sensory science. They answer different questions and are presented side by side, not as rivals.

COK-05 The six rasas and the five tastes

Before you start — COK-05. The *Charaka Samhita* lists six rasas and links each with the body's doshas; a balanced Indian thali tries to include all six. Modern science counts five basic tastes detected by receptors on the tongue, and treats pungency (chilli) and astringency (tannins) as touch and pain sensations rather than tastes. **Caution:** Ayurvedic food advice is traditional knowledge; for illness, consult a doctor.

☐ COK-05.1 The six rasas of Ayurveda

☐ **COK-05.1a Madhura (sweet)**: rice, milk, ghee, jaggery, dates; said to build and calm.

☐ **COK-05.1b Amla (sour)**: lemon, tamarind, curd, kokum, amla; said to stimulate appetite.

☐ **COK-05.1c Lavana (salty)**: rock salt, sea salt, black salt (*kala namak*).

☐ **COK-05.1d Katu (pungent)**: chilli, black pepper, ginger, mustard, garlic.

☐ **COK-05.1e Tikta (bitter)**: karela, methi, neem flowers (eaten at Ugadi), turmeric.

☐ **COK-05.1f Kashaya (astringent)**: raw banana, pomegranate, lentils, tea; the dry, puckering feeling.

☐ COK-05.2 The five basic tastes in science

☐ **COK-05.2a Sweet**: sugars, sensed by T1R2 and T1R3 receptors; a signal of energy.

☐ **COK-05.2b Salty**: sodium ions; a signal of minerals.

☐ **COK-05.2c Sour**: acids (hydrogen ions); a signal of ripeness or spoilage.

☐ **COK-05.2d Bitter**: about 25 receptor types (T2Rs); a warning of possible poison, which children dislike and adults learn to enjoy in coffee and karela.

☐ **COK-05.2e Umami**: glutamate and nucleotides (COK-00.05).

☐ **COK-05.2f Candidates**: kokumi (richness, studied by Ajinomoto researchers), fat taste (oleogustus), starchy taste.

☐ **COK-05.2g The "tongue map" myth**: the idea that each taste lives on one area of the tongue came from a mistranslation of a 1901 German paper; all areas sense all tastes.

COK-06 Aroma, texture, heat and pairing

☐ **COK-06.1 Aroma**: most of flavour is smell (COK-00.06); spices are bundles of aromatic compounds, which is why tempering in hot fat releases them.

☐ **COK-06.2 The Maillard reaction**: browning of proteins and sugars above about 140 °C (Louis-Camille Maillard, 1912); the flavour of roti, toast, seared meat and roasted coffee.

☐ **COK-06.3 Caramelisation**: sugar browning on its own (onions slowly fried for biryani are mostly Maillard plus caramelisation).

☐ **COK-06.4 Texture**: crisp, crunchy, chewy, creamy, spongy; Japanese has hundreds of words for it; texture contrasts make chaat delightful.

☐ **COK-06.5 Heat and spice**: the Scoville scale (COK-00.02); black pepper's piperine, mustard's and wasabi's isothiocyanates (which rise to the nose), ginger's gingerol.

☐ **COK-06.6 Temperature and colour**: food served hot smells stronger; colour changes how sweet or fresh we expect food to taste (the "red wine" experiments of Gil Morrot and colleagues, 2001).

☐ **COK-06.7 Flavour pairing**: the idea that foods sharing aroma compounds go well together (Heston Blumenthal's chocolate and caviar); a 2011 study by Ahn and colleagues found Western recipes tend to share compounds while East Asian recipes tend to avoid them; a 2015 analysis by Jain, Rakhi and Bagler (IIT Jodhpur) found Indian recipes also pair ingredients with few shared compounds.

☐ **COK-06.8 Balance**: salt reduces bitterness, acid brightens, fat carries aroma, sugar tames chilli; the core of seasoning "to taste".

PART 4 — INGREDIENTS AND THEIR JOURNEYS

About this Part. What food is made of, with where each ingredient began. Origins come from crop-history research (FAO, Achaya, the *Oxford Companion to Food*); some are debated.

COK-07 Grains, pulses, vegetables and fruits

- ☐ **COK-07.1 Rice**: Asian rice domesticated in the Yangtze region, with a separate early rice cultivation in the Ganga plains; basmati (GI, Indo-Gangetic plains), sona masoori, gobindobhog, joha, black rice; African rice is a separate species.
- ☐ **COK-07.2 Wheat**: from the Fertile Crescent; India's durum and bread wheats; atta, maida, suji (semolina), dalia.
- ☐ **COK-07.3 Millets (shree anna)**: jowar (sorghum), bajra (pearl millet), ragi (finger millet), and small millets (kodo, kutki, foxtail, barnyard, proso, little millet); 2023 was the UN International Year of Millets at India's proposal.
- ☐ **COK-07.4 Maize**: from Mexico; makki ki roti, bhutta, popcorn.
- ☐ **COK-07.5 Pulses (dal)**: toor (arhar), moong, masoor, urad, chana, rajma (from the Americas), lobia, moth, kulthi (horse gram); India is the world's largest producer and consumer of pulses.
- ☐ **COK-07.6 Vegetables**: native (brinjal, cucumber, gourds, taro), Old World (onion, garlic, spinach, cabbage) and New World (potato, tomato, chilli, capsicum, pumpkin, sweet potato).
- ☐ **COK-07.7 Fruits**: mango (India's national fruit, native to South and South-East Asia), banana, jackfruit (Kerala's state fruit), citrus (from the eastern Himalaya and South-East Asia), and New World guava, papaya, pineapple, custard apple.
- ☐ **COK-07.8 Nuts and seeds**: almonds, walnuts (Kashmir), cashew (from Brazil via the Portuguese), groundnut (from South America), sesame (domesticated in India, *til*), coconut.

COK-08 Spices and masalas

Before you start — COK-08. Spices drove world history: the search for pepper sent Vasco da Gama to Calicut (1498) and Columbus west. India grows more spices than any other country; the Spices Board India lists 52 (check indianspices.com).
See also: COK-17 (history).

- ☐ **COK-08.1 Native Indian spices**: black pepper (the "king of spices", Western Ghats), cardamom ("queen of spices"), turmeric, ginger, long pepper, cinnamon (true cinnamon is from Sri Lanka; Indian cooks often use cassia).
- ☐ **COK-08.2 Spices from elsewhere**: cumin and coriander (West Asia and the Mediterranean), cloves and nutmeg (the Maluku islands of Indonesia), saffron (Persia; grown in Kashmir's Pampore), chilli (the Americas), asafoetida (*hing*, from Iran and Afghanistan; India began growing it in Himachal in 2020).
- ☐ **COK-08.3 Whole-spice tempering sets**: panch phoron (Bengal: fenugreek, nigella, cumin, black mustard, fennel), the South Indian tadka (mustard, urad dal, curry leaves, dried chilli), the North Indian jeera-hing tadka.
- ☐ **COK-08.4 Masala families**: garam masala (warm, North), sambar podi and rasam podi (South), goda masala (Maharashtra), Chettinad masala, Kashmiri masala tikki (ver), chaat masala, Kolhapuri masala.
- ☐ **COK-08.5 World spice blends**: ras el hanout (Morocco), za'atar (Levant), berbere (Ethiopia), five-spice (China), shichimi (Japan), curry powder (a British invention for Indian flavours).
- ☐ **COK-08.6 Herbs**: coriander leaves, mint, curry leaves, methi, dill (*sowa*), basil and tulsi; world herbs such as parsley, oregano, thyme, rosemary, lemongrass, kaffir lime and Thai basil.

COK-09 Fats, dairy, proteins, sweeteners and ferments

- ☐ **COK-09.1 Oils and fats**: ghee, mustard oil (East and North), groundnut oil (West), sesame oil (*gingelly*, South), coconut oil (Kerala), olive oil (Mediterranean), butter and lard (Europe); smoke points matter for frying.
- ☐ **COK-09.2 Dairy**: milk, curd (dahi), buttermilk (chaas), paneer and chhena (acid-set), khoa and rabri (reduced milk), cheeses of the world; India is the world's largest milk producer, thanks to Operation Flood (from 1970) under Verghese Kurien.
- ☐ **COK-09.3 Meat**: goat and mutton, chicken, pork (North-East, Goa, Kerala, Coorg), beef (some states and communities; laws vary by state), game; cuts and cooking times.

☐ **COK-09.4 Fish and seafood**: hilsa (Bengal), rohu and catla, pomfret, surmai (kingfish), Bombay duck (*bombil*), prawns, crab; dried fish across the coasts.

☐ **COK-09.5 Eggs**: anda bhurji, egg curry, Parsi akuri, the world's omelettes.

☐ **COK-09.6 Plant proteins**: pulses, soy, tofu, tempeh, seitan, millets.

☐ **COK-09.7 Sweeteners**: jaggery (*gur*), khandsari, sugar (India refined sugar crystals early; "sugar" comes from Sanskrit *sharkara*), honey, palm jaggery (Bengal's *nolen gur*), date syrup.

☐ **COK-09.8 Fermented foods**: idli and dosa batter, dhokla, curd, kanji, jalebi batter, appam; Himalayan and North-Eastern ferments (gundruk, axone, tungrymbai, bamboo shoot); world ferments (kimchi, miso, sauerkraut, yoghurt, sourdough, kombucha, cheese, wine and beer).

PART 5 — TECHNIQUES

About this Part. How food is cooked. Each technique has a one-line "what" and its home cuisines. Recipes are described, not copied.

COK-10 Knife work and heat methods

☐ COK-10.1 Cutting

☐ **COK-10.1a Knife basics**: a sharp knife is safer than a blunt one; the claw grip; the Indian *boti* or *bonti* (a floor blade used in Bengal and Odisha) and the *hasiya*.

☐ **COK-10.1b Classic cuts**: dice, julienne, brunoise, chiffonade, mince, chop; Indian *bareek* (fine) and *lachha* (rings).

☐ **COK-10.1c Grinding**: sil-batta (grinding stone), mortar and pestle, the wet grinder for idli batter, mixer-grinder.

☐ COK-10.2 Dry heat

☐ **COK-10.2a Roasting and baking**: hot air in an oven or tandoor.

☐ **COK-10.2b Grilling and barbecuing**: direct heat: seekh kebab, satay, asado, braai.

☐ **COK-10.2c Dry roasting**: spices and dals on a tawa (*bhunna* without oil).

☐ **COK-10.2d Sand and ash roasting**: bhutta in sand, baati in embers, litti in cow-dung cake fire.

☐ COK-10.3 Moist heat

☐ **COK-10.3a Boiling and simmering**: dal, rice, stocks.

☐ **COK-10.3b Steaming**: idli, dhokla, momo, puttu, dim sum.

☐ **COK-10.3c Pressure cooking**: higher boiling point (about 120 °C) cooks dal fast; Denis Papin's "digester" (1679) is the ancestor; India's Hawkins (1959) and Prestige brands made it universal.

☐ **COK-10.3d Braising and stewing**: slow cooking in liquid: nihari, rogan josh, beef stew.

☐ **COK-10.3e Poaching**: gentle simmering (eggs, fish, *rasgulla* in syrup).

☐ COK-10.4 Fat-based heat

☐ **COK-10.4a Sautéing and stir-frying**: high heat, little oil, moving food: the Chinese wok and Indian kadhai.

☐ **COK-10.4b Shallow frying**: tikki, cutlet, paratha.

☐ **COK-10.4c Deep frying**: pakora, samosa, puri, jalebi, tempura; keep oil at about 170 to 190 °C.

COK-11 Indian techniques

Before you start — COK-11. Many Indian techniques have no exact English word. These are the ones every Indian cook knows by hand.

☐ **COK-11.1 Tadka, chhaunk, baghaar, oggarane (tempering)**: whole spices fried in hot ghee or oil and poured over dal or added at the start; releases aroma into the fat.

☐ **COK-11.2 Bhuna (roasting a masala)**: frying onion, ginger-garlic, tomato and ground spices until the oil separates; the heart of North Indian gravies.

☐ **COK-11.3 Dum (steam-sealed slow cooking)**: a pot sealed with dough and heated gently from above and below; dum biryani, dum aloo, dum pukht of Awadh.

☐ **COK-11.4 Talna (frying)**: the Hindi word for frying, from talna fish to puris.

☐ **COK-11.5 Tandoor**: a clay oven, often in the ground, reaching over 400 °C; naan, tandoori roti and chicken; its form is ancient across West and Central Asia, and tandoori chicken in its modern restaurant form was popularised by Moti Mahal in Delhi.

☐ **COK-11.6 Dhungar (smoking)**: placing a hot coal in a small bowl inside the pot, adding ghee and covering, so the dish absorbs smoke; used for dal, raita and kebabs.

☐ **COK-11.7 Dhuan, sigri and angithi cooking**: charcoal braziers for slow heat.

☐ **COK-11.8 Kadhai and tawa cooking**: the wok-like kadhai and flat tawa; the Mughal and Punjabi *tawa* kebabs.

☐ **COK-11.9 Fermenting batters**: idli and dosa batter left overnight; the warmth of the kitchen decides the sourness.

☐ **COK-11.10 Reducing milk**: making khoa, rabri and basundi by slow stirring.

☐ **COK-11.11 Banana-leaf and clay-pot cooking**: patrode, patra ni machhi, handi meat, matka kulfi.

COK-12 Baking, fermentation, preservation and modern methods

☐ **COK-12.1 Baking**: breads (yeast, sourdough), cakes, biscuits, pastry (shortcrust, puff, choux); Indian bakeries of Goa and the Irani cafés; *nankhatai* and Kerala's plum cake.

☐ **COK-12.2 Fermentation**: yeast (bread, beer), lactic acid bacteria (curd, kimchi, idli, kanji), moulds (cheese, soy sauce, miso); the scientist Louis Pasteur showed in the 1850s and 1860s that microbes cause fermentation.

☐ **COK-12.3 Pickling**: in oil and spices (Indian *achaar*), in vinegar (Goan and Anglo-Indian), in brine (sauerkraut); the sun-cured mango achaar of North India and the avakaya of Andhra.

☐ **COK-12.4 Drying**: sun-dried vegetables (*sukha*, ker sangri, vadis, papads, sandige), dried fish, jerky.

☐ **COK-12.5 Smoking and curing**: Naga and Khasi smoked meats, European ham and salmon.

☐ **COK-12.6 Sugar preserving**: murabba, jams, candied peel, gulkand.

☐ **COK-12.7 Freezing and canning**: Nicolas Appert's bottled foods (1810); Clarence Birdseye's quick-freezing (1920s).

☐ **COK-12.8 Molecular gastronomy and modernist cooking**: the science of cooking, named by Nicholas Kurti and Hervé This (1988); spherification, foams and sous-vide (cooking sealed food in a precise water bath); chefs Ferran Adrià (elBulli) and Heston Blumenthal (The Fat Duck); Gaggan Anand's "progressive Indian" food.

PART 6 — DISH FAMILIES

About this Part. What food becomes. Each family lists dishes from India and the world, each with one line on what it is and where it began. Origins of popular dishes are often legends; we mark them as such.

COK-13 Breads, rice and grain dishes

☐ **COK-13.1 Indian flatbreads**: roti and chapati (whole wheat, tawa), phulka (puffed on flame), paratha (layered, stuffed), puri and bhatura (fried), naan and kulcha (tandoor, leavened), bhakri and thalipeeth (Maharashtra), rotla (Gujarat), rumali roti, sheermal and baqarkhani (Mughlai).

☐ **COK-13.2 Batter breads and pancakes**: dosa, uttapam, appam, pesarattu, neer dosa, chilla (besan), malpua; crêpes, blini, Ethiopian injera.

☐ **COK-13.3 World breads**: baguette, sourdough, ciabatta, bagel, pita, lavash, tortilla, Chinese bao, pav (from Portuguese *pão*).

☐ **COK-13.4 Rice dishes**: biryani (many regional styles: Hyderabadi, Lucknowi, Kolkata with potato, Malabar, Ambur, Dindigul), pulao, khichdi (the ancestor of the Anglo-Indian kedgeree), pongal, curd rice, bisi bele bath, lemon rice; world rice dishes: paella, risotto, jollof, nasi goreng, Iranian polo, sushi.

☐ **COK-13.5 Porridges and grain dishes**: upma, poha, dalia, ragi mudde, sattu, haleem; oatmeal, congee, polenta, couscous, grits.

☐ **COK-13.6 Noodles and pasta**: Chinese noodles, ramen, udon, pho, pad thai, Italian pasta shapes; Indian sevaiyan, idiyappam (string hoppers), hakka noodles, Maggi (in India since 1983).

COK-14 Curries, dals, soups and vegetables

Before you start — COK-14. "Curry" is a European word, probably from Tamil *kari* (a spiced sauce or relish), used for any spiced dish with gravy. Indians name dishes by ingredient and method instead: *kadhai paneer*, *dum aloo*, *macher jhol*. Thai, Japanese, Malaysian and Caribbean curries are their own traditions.

☐ **COK-14.1 Dals**: dal tadka, dal makhani, sambar, rasam, varan, Gujarati sweet-sour dal, cholar dal (Bengal), dalma (Odisha), panchmel dal (Rajasthan).

☐ **COK-14.2 Gravies and curries, vegetarian**: shahi paneer, palak paneer, chole, rajma, kadhi, malai kofta, avial (Kerala), undhiyu, sarson ka saag, gatte ki sabzi.

☐ **COK-14.3 Gravies and curries, non-vegetarian**: rogan josh, laal maas, korma, butter chicken, chicken chettinad, Goan fish curry, macher jhol, vindaloo, nihari, Kerala stew, prawn malai curry.

☐ **COK-14.4 Dry vegetable dishes (sukhi sabzi)**: aloo gobi, bhindi masala, baingan bharta, thoran and poriyal (South), ker sangri.

☐ **COK-14.5 World curries and stews**: Thai green and red curry, Japanese kare (from British naval curry), Malaysian rendang, Caribbean curry goat, Ethiopian wat, Irish stew, French ratatouille and bouillabaisse, goulash.

☐ **COK-14.6 Soups**: rasam and shorba, mulligatawny (from Tamil *milagu tanni*, "pepper water"), thukpa (Himalaya), tom yum, miso soup, minestrone, French onion, borscht, gazpacho (served cold).

COK-15 Snacks, street food and salads

☐ **COK-15.1 Chaat**: pani puri (golgappa, puchka), bhel puri, sev puri, aloo tikki, papdi chaat, dahi bhalla, raj kachori; a mix of sweet, sour, spicy, crunchy and soft.

☐ **COK-15.2 Fried snacks**: samosa (from Central Asian *sambusa*, recorded in India by the 13th century), kachori, pakora and bhajia, vada (medu, batata), mirchi vada, Bengal's telebhaja.

☐ **COK-15.3 Steamed and baked snacks**: dhokla, khandvi, idli, momo, patrode, Mumbai's vada pav and pav bhaji (invented for mill workers in the 1850s to 1860s, by popular account).

☐ **COK-15.4 Rolls and wraps**: Kolkata kathi roll (Nizam's, about 1932, by popular account), frankie (Mumbai), shawarma, burrito, spring roll.

☐ **COK-15.5 Namkeen and dry snacks**: Bikaneri bhujia (GI, 2010), Ratlami sev, chakli, murukku, mathri, chivda, khakhra.

☐ **COK-15.6 World street food**: tacos, falafel, banh mi, hot dogs, fish and chips, satay, dumplings; Singapore's hawker culture (UNESCO, 2020).

☐ **COK-15.7 Salads and raw dishes**: kachumber, koshimbir, Kerala's raw-mango salads; Greek salad, tabbouleh, som tam, ceviche, poke.

☐ **COK-15.8 Accompaniments**: chutneys, raita, pickles (achaar), papad, salan; world dips and sauces (salsa, hummus, guacamole, chimichurri, mayonnaise, ketchup, whose name may come from a Hokkien word for fish sauce).

COK-16 Sweets, desserts and drinks

☐ COK-16.1 Indian sweets (mithai)

☐ **COK-16.1a Milk sweets**: rasgulla and sandesh (chhena, Bengal and Odisha), kalakand, peda (Mathura, Dharwad GI), barfi, rabri, rasmalai, kulfi, basundi.

☐ **COK-16.1b Flour and gram sweets**: laddu (besan, boondi, motichoor, Tirupati), Mysore pak, soan papdi, ghevar (Rajasthan), balushahi, gujiya, modak.

☐ **COK-16.1c Fried and syrup sweets**: jalebi (from West Asian *zalabiya*), imarti, gulab jamun (with a Persian name, "rose water drop"), malpua, chhena poda.

☐ **COK-16.1d Puddings and halwas**: kheer and payasam (the oldest recorded Indian dessert), gajar halwa, moong dal halwa, sheer khurma, phirni, shrikhand (Maharashtra and Gujarat), double ka meetha, bebinca (Goa).

☐ **COK-16.1e Jaggery and festival sweets**: til laddu and chikki (Makar Sankranti), pitha (Bihu and Poush Sankranti), ariselu, thekua (Chhath), nolen gur sandesh.

☐ COK-16.2 World desserts

☐ **COK-16.2a European**: cakes, tarts, croissant (Viennese-French), tiramisu, crème brûlée, gelato, macarons, Christmas pudding.

☐ **COK-16.2b West Asian**: baklava, kunafa, Turkish delight, halva.

☐ **COK-16.2c East Asian**: mochi, mooncake, bingsu, mango sticky rice.

☐ **COK-16.2d The Americas**: brigadeiro, tres leches, churros, brownies, pumpkin pie.

☐ **COK-16.2e Chocolate**: cacao drunk in Mesoamerica for some 3,000 years or more; solid eating chocolate is a 19th-century European invention.

☐ COK-16.3 Drinks

☐ **COK-16.3a Tea**: Camellia sinensis from China; Assam's native variety found by the British in the 1820s; Darjeeling (India's first GI, 2004), Nilgiri; masala chai spread widely after the Tea Board's promotions of the 20th century; Kashmiri noon chai and kahwa; world teas: matcha, oolong, British tea, Moroccan mint tea.

☐ **COK-16.3b Coffee**: from Ethiopia via Yemen; legend says Baba Budan smuggled seven beans to Chikmagalur, Karnataka, in the 17th century; South Indian filter coffee; espresso, Turkish coffee, the world café culture.

☐ **COK-16.3c Dairy and yoghurt drinks**: lassi, chaas (buttermilk), badam milk, thandai (Holi), haldi doodh; ayran, kefir.

☐ **COK-16.3d Sherbets and coolers**: aam panna, kokum sharbat, jaljeera, nimbu pani, rose and khus sherbets, sattu drink, sugarcane juice, nannari (sarsaparilla), Goli soda; the word "sherbet" comes from Arabic *sharbah* (drink).

☐ **COK-16.3e Fermented and traditional drinks**: kanji, toddy, rice beers of the North-East and tribal India, feni (Goa, GI); wine, beer, sake and spirits of the world. *Note:* alcohol laws and age limits vary by state and country.

PART 7 — REGISTERS

About this Part. Four registers: 30 dish cards, a year-wise food timeline, the great awards and guides with their latest results, and a selection of India's GI-tagged foods. All are a sourced selection; the full lists grow on the website.

COK-17 Dish cards (register of 30 dishes)

Before you start — COK-17. The brief's card has nine fields. To fit the page it is split into two linked tables. Diet codes: V vegetarian (with dairy), Vg vegan, J Jain-friendly as usually made, N non-vegetarian. "History" lines give the best-supported account; legends are marked.

☐ COK-17.1 Card A: identity

Dish (local · English)	Region	Category	Main ingredients	Technique	Diet
Dal baati churma · baked wheat balls with lentils	Rajasthan	Meal	Wheat, ghee, mixed dal, jaggery	Baking in embers, boiling	V
Ker sangri · desert beans and berries	Rajasthan	Vegetable	Dried ker berries, sangri pods	Soaking, sautéing	Vg
Laal maas · red mutton curry	Rajasthan (Mewar)	Curry	Mutton, Mathania chillies, curd	Bhuna, slow cooking	N
Sarson da saag · mustard greens	Punjab	Vegetable	Mustard and other greens, maize flour	Slow simmer, mashing	V
Chole bhature · chickpeas with fried bread	Punjab and Delhi	Meal	Chickpeas, maida, spices	Boiling, deep frying	V
Rogan josh · Kashmiri red lamb	Kashmir	Curry	Lamb, ratan jot or Kashmiri chilli, fennel, ginger	Braising	N
Galouti kebab · melt-in-the-mouth kebab	Lucknow (Awadh)	Kebab	Minced meat, papaya, spices	Fine mincing, tawa	N
Biryani, Hyderabadi · layered rice and meat	Telangana	Rice	Basmati, goat or chicken, saffron, fried onion	Kacchi dum	N
Litti chokha · stuffed wheat balls with mash	Bihar	Meal	Wheat, sattu, brinjal, potato, tomato	Roasting in fire	Vg (V with ghee)
Macher jhol · fish in light gravy	Bengal	Curry	Rohu or other fish, potato, panch phoron	Frying, simmering	N
Rosogolla · chhena balls in syrup	Odisha and Bengal	Sweet	Chhena, sugar	Kneading, poaching	V
Masor tenga · sour fish curry	Assam	Curry	Fish, tomato or elephant apple	Simmering	N
Smoked pork with bamboo shoot	Nagaland	Meat	Pork, fermented bamboo shoot, bhut jolokia	Smoking, stewing	N
Dhokla · steamed gram cake	Gujarat	Snack	Gram flour or rice and dal batter	Fermenting, steaming	V (Vg without curd)
Undhiyu · winter mixed vegetables	Gujarat (Surat)	Vegetable	Surti papdi, yam, aubergine, methi muthia	Slow cooking (traditionally in an upturned pot)	Vg
Puran poli · sweet stuffed flatbread	Maharashtra	Sweet bread	Chana dal, jaggery, wheat	Stuffing, tawa	V
Vada pav · potato fritter in a bun	Mumbai	Street food	Potato, gram flour, pav, chutneys	Deep frying	Vg
Goan fish curry · coconut fish curry	Goa	Curry	Fish, coconut, kokum or tamarind, chilli	Grinding, simmering	N

Dhansak · lentils with meat	Parsi	Curry	Mutton, mixed dals, vegetables	Simmering, mashing	N
Masala dosa · rice crêpe with potato	Karnataka (Udupi)	Breakfast	Rice, urad dal, potato	Fermenting, griddle	Vg
Sambar · lentil and vegetable stew	Tamil Nadu and the South	Dal	Toor dal, tamarind, vegetables, sambar powder	Simmering, tadka	Vg
Appam with stew	Kerala	Meal	Fermented rice batter, coconut milk, vegetables or meat	Fermenting, appachatti pan	Vg or N
Avial · mixed vegetables in coconut	Kerala	Vegetable	Vegetables, coconut, curd, coconut oil	Simmering	V
Haleem · wheat and meat porridge	Hyderabad	Stew	Wheat, meat, lentils, ghee	Slow cooking, pounding	N
Gongura pachadi · sorrel chutney	Andhra Pradesh	Chutney	Gongura leaves, chilli, oil	Frying, grinding	Vg
Kheer and payasam · rice pudding	All India	Dessert	Rice, milk, sugar or jaggery	Slow boiling	V
Khichdi · rice and lentils	All India	Comfort food	Rice, moong dal, ghee	Boiling	V
Momo · dumplings	Tibet, Nepal, Sikkim, the Himalaya	Snack	Wheat dough, vegetable or meat filling	Steaming	Vg or N
Samosa · stuffed pastry	All India (Central Asian roots)	Snack	Maida, potato, peas	Deep frying	Vg
Jalebi · fried syrup spirals	All India (West Asian roots)	Sweet	Fermented maida batter, sugar syrup	Deep frying, soaking	V

☐ COK-17.2 Card B: festival, season, history and source

Dish	Festival or season	History note	Health note	Pairs with	Source
Dal baati churma	Weddings, Gangaur, any feast	Linked with Rajput soldiers by tradition; baati baked in sand or embers	Heavy in ghee	Buttermilk	Achaya; Rajasthan Tourism
Ker sangri	Year-round; travel food	Desert foods that keep for months	High fibre	Bajra roti	Achaya
Laal maas	Winter, hunting feasts (historic)	Royal Mewar kitchens; originally game meat	Very hot	Bajra roti	Rajasthan food writers
Sarson da saag	Winter (Lohri)	Village food of Punjab's winter fields	Rich in iron and vitamin K	Makki di roti, white butter	Achaya
Chole bhature	Year-round	Popular in Delhi after Partition	Fried; occasional food	Lassi, pickled onions	Delhi food histories
Rogan josh	Wazwan feasts	Persian name ("red oil" or "red juice"); Mughal links	Rich	Rice	Kashmiri cookbooks
Galouti kebab	Eid, Awadhi feasts	Legend: made for a toothless nawab	Rich	Ulte tawe ka paratha	Awadhi food histories
Hyderabadi biryani	Eid, weddings	Nizami court cuisine; *kacchi* means raw meat cooked with rice	Rich	Mirchi ka salan, raita	GI and food histories
Litti chokha	Year-round; Chhath region	Village and traveller's food	Sattu is high in protein	Ghee, chutney	Bihar food writers
Macher jhol	Daily meal	Bengal's everyday fish curry	Light	Rice	Bengali cookbooks
Rosogolla	Durga Puja, year-round	Origin disputed between Odisha (Pahala, Puri temple) and Bengal (Nobin	Sugar-rich	—	GI Registry

		Chandra Das, 1868); both have GI tags			
Masor tenga	Summer	Light sour fish for hot weather	Light	Rice	Assamese cookbooks
Smoked pork with bamboo shoot	Hornbill Festival, feasts	Smoking preserves meat over the kitchen fire	Very hot	Rice	Naga food writers
Dhokla	Year-round, breakfast	Named in the old Jain text *Varnaka Samuchchaya*, as cited by food historians	Fermented, light	Green chutney	Achaya
Undhiyu	Uttarayan (Makar Sankranti)	Winter vegetables of Surat	Rich in vegetables	Puri, shrikhand	Gujarati cookbooks
Puran poli	Holi, Gudi Padwa	Mentioned in medieval Marathi and Kannada texts as *holige*	Sweet	Katachi amti, ghee	Achaya
Vada pav	Year-round	Credited to Ashok Vaidya near Dadar station, about 1966	Fried	Fried chillies	Mumbai press
Goan fish curry	Daily meal	Konkan coast staple; Portuguese-era ingredients	Light	Rice	Goan cookbooks
Dhansak	Sunday lunch	Parsi family meal, not served at celebrations	Balanced	Brown rice, kachumber	Parsi cookbooks
Masala dosa	Breakfast, year-round	Spread by Udupi restaurateurs in the 20th century	Fermented	Sambar, chutney	Achaya; Udupi histories
Sambar	Daily meal	Legend links it with the Thanjavur Maratha court (17th century)	Balanced	Rice, idli, dosa	Food histories
Appam with stew	Christmas, Easter (Syrian Christian)	Kerala's coastal trading cuisine	Coconut-rich	—	Kerala cookbooks
Avial	Onam sadya	Legend links it with Bhima of the *Mahabharata*	Vegetable-rich	Rice	Kerala cookbooks
Haleem	Ramzan	From Arab *harees*; brought to Hyderabad by Arab soldiers of the Nizams	High protein	—	GI Registry (2010)
Gongura pachadi	Year-round	Andhra's signature sour leaf	Very hot	Rice and ghee	Andhra cookbooks
Kheer and payasam	Festivals, temple offerings	*Payasa* appears in early Sanskrit and Buddhist texts	Sweet	—	Achaya
Khichdi	Makar Sankranti; illness	Described by Ibn Battuta (14th century)	Easy to digest	Curd, papad, pickle	Achaya
Momo	Year-round	From Tibetan cooking; spread by Tibetan and Nepali communities	Steamed	Tomato-chilli chutney	Himalayan food writers
Samosa	Year-round	Persian *sanbosag*; noted by Amir Khusrau and Ibn Battuta	Fried	Tamarind and mint chutney	Achaya
Jalebi	Festivals, breakfast in North India	Arabic *zalabiya*, recorded in 10th-century Arabic	Sugar-rich	Rabri, milk	Achaya; Oxford Companion to Food

		cookbooks			

COK-18 The Food Timeline (year-wise register)

Year	Event	Where	Why it matters
c. 1 million years ago	Evidence of controlled fire at Wonderwerk Cave	South Africa	Cooking may have begun
c. 14,400 years ago	Charred flatbread crumbs at Shubayqa 1	Jordan	Bread older than farming
c. 9500 BCE	Farming begins in the Fertile Crescent	West Asia	Grains, pulses, flax
c. 7000 BCE	Barley and wheat at Mehrgarh	South Asia	Earliest farming in South Asia
c. 2500 BCE	Indus cities: sesame, pulses, possibly early curry-like dishes (starch grains of turmeric and ginger at Farmana)	Haryana	Oldest evidence of Indian spice use
c. 1750 BCE	Babylonian recipe tablets (Yale culinary tablets)	Mesopotamia	Oldest written recipes
c. 1st century CE	Roman spice trade with Muziris	Kerala	Pepper drives world trade
c. 400 CE	*Apicius*, Roman cookbook	Rome	Classical European cookery
1130	*Manasollasa* of King Someshvara III	Kalyani (Karnataka)	Indian royal food encyclopaedia
1498	Vasco da Gama reaches Calicut	Kerala	Sea route for spices
1500s	Chilli, potato, tomato arrive via Portuguese trade	Goa, then India	The Columbian Exchange
c. 1590s	*Ain-i-Akbari* records Akbar's kitchens	Mughal India	Detailed royal recipes
1765	Boulanger's eating house, often called the first restaurant	Paris	Birth of the modern restaurant
1810	Appert's preserved foods	France	Start of canning
1903	Escoffier, *Le Guide Culinaire*	France	Modern professional cooking
1908	Ikeda identifies umami	Japan	Fifth basic taste
1926	Michelin's first stars	France	Restaurant guides
1947	Moti Mahal opens in Daryaganj and popularises tandoori chicken	Delhi	Restaurant Punjabi food
1955	First McDonald's franchise by Ray Kroc	USA	Global fast food
1970	Operation Flood begins	India	India becomes the largest milk producer
1987	First Bocuse d'Or	Lyon	Chef competition
2002	First World's 50 Best Restaurants list	London	Global restaurant rankings
2004	Darjeeling tea gets India's first GI tag	India	Protecting regional foods
2006	FSS Act; FSSAI set up 2008	India	National food safety law
2013	National Food Security Act	India	Legal right to subsidised grain
2023	International Year of Millets	United Nations, India's proposal	Millets back on the plate
2025	Italian cuisine inscribed by UNESCO	Italy	First national cuisine as a whole
2026	Asador Etxebarri named No. 1 at the World's 50 Best Restaurants, Lima	Spain and Peru	Latest world ranking

COK-19 Awards, guides and GI foods (register)

Award or guide	Body	Since	What it honours	Latest (checked 13	Note

				Nov 2026)	
Michelin Guide stars	Michelin	1926 (stars)	One to three stars for restaurants; Bib Gourmand for good value	India has no Michelin restaurant guide yet; 47 Indian hotels received Michelin Keys in 2026	Indian-born chefs abroad hold stars (Vineet Bhatia and Atul Kochhar, the first in 2001)
The World's 50 Best Restaurants	William Reed	2002	An annual ranking voted by about 1,000 experts	2026: Asador Etxebarri (Axpe, Spain), announced in Lima; 2025: Maido (Lima)	Regional lists include Asia's 50 Best
James Beard Awards	James Beard Foundation	1991	US chefs, restaurants, books and media	Announced each June	The "Oscars of food" in the USA
Bocuse d'Or	Founded by Paul Bocuse	1987	A world chef competition held in Lyon every two years	2025: France (Paul Marcon)	India has taken part in qualifying rounds
GI tags for food	GI Registry, Chennai	2004 (Darjeeling tea)	Foods tied to a place	Over 600 GI products registered in all categories (check ipindia.gov.in)	Examples below
World Food Prize	World Food Prize Foundation	1987	Work that improves the world's food supply	Announced yearly (worldfoodprize.org)	M. S. Swaminathan was the first laureate (1987)

☐ COK-19.1 Selected GI-tagged foods of India

☐ **Drinks and spices**: Darjeeling tea (2004), Coorg arabica coffee, Malabar pepper, Alleppey green cardamom, Byadgi chilli, Guntur sannam chilli, Naga mircha, Kashmir saffron, Lakadong turmeric, Erode turmeric.

☐ **Sweets**: Tirupati laddu, Dharwad pedha, Bikaneri bhujia, Banglar rosogolla and Odisha rasagola, Joynagar moa, Bandar laddu, Srivilliputtur palkova, Kovilpatti kadalai mittai.

☐ **Grains and fruit**: basmati rice, Navara rice, Joha rice, Kalanamak rice, Chak-hao (Manipur black rice), Alphonso mango (Ratnagiri), Malihabadi dussehri, Banganapalle mango, Nagpur orange, Shahi litchi (Muzaffarpur).

☐ **Dishes and others**: Hyderabadi haleem, Similipal kai chutney, Goan feni, Ratlami sev, Kolhapuri jaggery.

PART 8 — HISTORY

About this Part. The story of food in eight chapters, each a website page. The timeline (COK-18) gives the dates. **See also:** GRD (the history of farming).

COK-20 From the first fire to global fusion

☐ **COK-20.1 Fire and the first cooks**: the cooking hypothesis (COK-00.01); earth ovens, roasting pits and stone boiling.

☐ **COK-20.2 Farming and the first cuisines**: grains, bread, beer and dairy; the Indus civilisation's crops, grinding stones and the Farmana spice traces.

☐ **COK-20.3 Food in ancient India**: Vedic offerings of barley cakes (*apupa*), ghee and soma; Buddhist and Jain rules on food; Ayurveda's *Charaka Samhita* and *Sushruta Samhita* on diet; Tamil Sangam poems describing feasts; K. T. Achaya's work as the guide.

☐ **COK-20.4 Medieval royal kitchens**: the *Manasollasa* (1130) with its recipes for rice, meats, sweets and drinks; the *Supa Shastra* of Mangarasa III (1508, Jain vegetarian cookery); the Mughal kitchens in the *Ain-i-Akbari* and the *Nuskha-e-Shahjahani*; the *Nimatnama* of the Malwa sultans (about 1500), with illustrated recipes.

☐ **COK-20.5 The spice routes**: Arab, Indian, Chinese and Roman traders; Muziris and Calicut; the Portuguese, Dutch and British East India Companies; nutmeg and the Banda Islands massacre (1621), a reminder of spice's cruel side.

☐ **COK-20.6 The Columbian Exchange and colonial kitchens**: new crops in India (COK-00.03); British tea plantations, Anglo-Indian cooking, the "curry house"; indentured Indian workers who took roti and curry to the Caribbean, Fiji, Mauritius and South Africa.

☐ **COK-20.7 Restaurants, industry and fast food**: Paris restaurants after 1765; Escoffier's brigade system; canning, refrigeration and supermarkets; McDonald's and global fast food; India's Udupi restaurants, dhabas, Irani cafés and the Delhi Punjabi restaurant after 1947.

☐ **COK-20.8 Global fusion and the digital kitchen**: Indian-Chinese, Nikkei, Tex-Mex; food delivery apps (Zomato 2008, Swiggy 2014); cooking shows and YouTube; the millet revival; climate-aware eating.

PART 9 — PEOPLE, AWARDS AND GUIDES

About this Part. The chefs, writers and scientists who shaped how we cook and think about food. The awards register is COK-19.

COK-21 Chefs and food writers

☐ COK-21.1 India

☐ **COK-21.1a K. T. Achaya (1923 to 2002)**: oil scientist and India's great food historian (*Indian Food: A Historical Companion*, 1994; *A Historical Dictionary of Indian Food*, 1998).

☐ **COK-21.1b Madhur Jaffrey (born 1933)**: actor and writer who introduced Indian home cooking to the West (*An Invitation to Indian Cooking*, 1973; BBC series, 1982).

☐ **COK-21.1c Tarla Dalal (1936 to 2013)**: vegetarian cookbook writer with over 100 books; Padma Shri 2007, the first person honoured for cooking.

☐ **COK-21.1d Sanjeev Kapoor (born 1964)**: chef of *Khana Khazana* (from 1993), one of Asia's longest-running cooking shows, and a TV food channel.

☐ **COK-21.1e Imtiaz Qureshi (1931 to 2024)**: master of Awadhi dum pukht; Padma Shri 2016.

☐ **COK-21.1f Manjit Gill, Hemant Oberoi and Ananda Solomon**: hotel chefs who brought regional Indian food into fine dining.

☐ **COK-21.1g Gaggan Anand and Himanshu Saini**: chefs whose Indian-inspired restaurants abroad (Bangkok; Tresind Studio, Dubai, three Michelin stars in 2025) topped world lists.

☐ **COK-21.1h Vikas Khanna, Ranveer Brar, Kunal Kapur and Garima Arora**: TV and restaurant chefs; Garima Arora's Gaa (Bangkok) won a Michelin star in 2018, making her the first Indian woman chef with one.

☐ **COK-21.1i Food writers and historians**: Pushpesh Pant (*India: The Cookbook*, 2010), Vir Sanghvi (*Rude Food*), Chitrita Banerji on Bengal, Colleen Taylor Sen (*Feasts and Fasts*, 2015), Lizzie Collingham (*Curry*, 2005), Kurush Dalal (food archaeologist), Kalyan Karmakar, Marryam Reshii (*The Flavour of Spice*).

☐ **COK-21.1j Home cooks**: the countless women, and men, who kept regional recipes alive without credit; recording them is part of this project.

☐ COK-21.2 The world

☐ **COK-21.2a Marie-Antoine Carême (1784 to 1833)**: the first celebrity chef; built grand French cuisine.

☐ **COK-21.2b Auguste Escoffier (1846 to 1935)**: modernised French cooking and organised the kitchen brigade.

☐ **COK-21.2c Isabella Beeton (1836 to 1865)**: *Book of Household Management* (1861), Britain's best-known cookbook.

☐ **COK-21.2d Julia Child (1912 to 2004)**: brought French cooking to American homes (*Mastering the Art of French Cooking*, 1961).

☐ **COK-21.2e Paul Bocuse (1926 to 2018)**: a leader of *nouvelle cuisine*; founded the Bocuse d'Or.

☐ **COK-21.2f Ferran Adrià, René Redzepi and Massimo Bottura**: avant-garde, New Nordic and modern Italian; elBulli, Noma and Osteria Francescana.

☐ **COK-21.2g Alice Waters (born 1944)**: Chez Panisse (1971) and the farm-to-table movement.

☐ **COK-21.2h Anthony Bourdain (1956 to 2018)**: *Kitchen Confidential* (2000) and travel shows that celebrated street food worldwide.

☐ **COK-21.2i Harold McGee (born 1951)**: *On Food and Cooking* (1984), the bible of kitchen science.

☐ **COK-21.2j Samin Nosrat and Yotam Ottolenghi**: *Salt, Fat, Acid, Heat* (2017); Ottolenghi's vegetable-forward Middle Eastern cooking.

☐ **COK-21.2k Alan Davidson (1924 to 2000)**: *The Oxford Companion to Food* (1999).

☐ **COK-21.2l José Andrés**: chef and founder of World Central Kitchen (2010), which feeds people after disasters.

PART 10 — IDEAS: PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY

About this Part. Food as identity, faith, memory, ethics and politics. Ideas are presented fairly, with their sources.

COK-22 Food, identity and the sacred

☐ **COK-22.1 Food and identity**: "Tell me what you eat, and I will tell you what you are" (Jean Anthelme Brillat-Savarin, *The Physiology of Taste*, 1825); food marks region, caste, class and religion in India, sometimes painfully; Arjun Appadurai's essay "How to Make a National Cuisine" (1988).

☐ **COK-22.2 Satvik, rajasik and tamasik**: the *Bhagavad Gita* (chapter 17) classes food by its effect on the mind: pure and calming, stimulating, or dulling.

☐ **COK-22.3 Sacred food and fasting**: prasad and langar; Navratri, Ekadashi and Karva Chauth fasts with their own foods (sabudana, kuttu, singhara); Ramzan roza and iftar; Christian Lent; Jain *paryushan*; Yom Kippur.

☐ **COK-22.4 Food rules across faiths**: halal, kosher, Jain, Hindu vegetarian traditions, Buddhist monastic food, Rastafarian *ital*.

☐ **COK-22.5 Eating together**: the shared thali, the Sikh langar's equality, Mediterranean long tables; research links family meals with better diet in children.

COK-23 Psychology, ethics and sustainability

☐ **COK-23.1 Comfort food and memory**: COK-00.06; why we crave childhood foods when stressed or homesick.

☐ **COK-23.2 Taste preferences**: babies prefer sweet and dislike bitter; liking for chilli, coffee and bitter greens is learned; "supertasters" (Linda Bartoshuk) find bitter tastes stronger.

☐ **COK-23.3 Food ethics**: vegetarianism and animal welfare (from Ashoka's edicts to Peter Singer), fair wages for farm and kitchen workers, cultural appropriation versus exchange.

☐ **COK-23.4 Sustainability**: food systems produce roughly a third of human greenhouse emissions (Crippa and colleagues, *Nature Food*, 2021); local and seasonal eating, plant-rich diets (the EAT-Lancet report, 2019), millets and water.

☐ **COK-23.5 Food waste**: the UNEP Food Waste Index (2024) estimates about 1.05 billion tonnes of food wasted in 2022; Indian traditions of using everything (peel chutneys, stale-roti dishes).

☐ **COK-23.6 Hunger and the right to food**: India's National Food Security Act (2013), mid-day meals (PM POSHAN), Annapurna traditions; the FAO's *State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World* reports.

PART 11 — HEALTH AND SAFETY

About this Part. Basic facts only. **Always consult a doctor or registered dietitian for medical diets, allergies, pregnancy, diabetes, kidney or heart disease.** Nutrition guidance follows ICMR–NIN's *Dietary Guidelines for Indians* (2024), the WHO and FSSAI.

COK-24 Nutrition, safety and allergies

- ☐ **COK-24.1 Nutrition basics**: carbohydrates, proteins, fats, vitamins, minerals, fibre and water; the "My Plate for the Day" of ICMR–NIN suggests half the plate as vegetables and fruit.
- ☐ **COK-24.2 Salt, sugar and oil**: the WHO recommends less than 5 g of salt a day for adults and keeping free sugars under 10 per cent of energy; FSSAI's "Eat Right India" campaign targets less salt, sugar and trans fat.
- ☐ **COK-24.3 Food safety at home**: the WHO's five keys: keep clean, separate raw and cooked, cook thoroughly, keep food at safe temperatures (the danger zone is about 5 to 60 °C), use safe water and raw materials.
- ☐ **COK-24.4 Allergies and intolerances**: common allergens include milk, eggs, peanuts, tree nuts, soy, wheat, fish, shellfish and sesame; lactose intolerance and coeliac disease (gluten) are different conditions; read labels; FSSAI requires allergen labelling.
- ☐ **COK-24.5 Adulteration**: FSSAI's simple home tests (for example, water tests for chalk in sugar or starch in milk); report through the Food Safety Connect app.
- ☐ **COK-24.6 Special diets**: diabetic, low-salt, gluten-free, vegan, Jain and fasting diets; plan them with a professional.

PART 12 — THE PRACTICAL GUIDE

About this Part. Hands-on pages for a new cook.

COK-25 Kitchen basics and a beginner's 20 dishes

☐ **COK-25.1 Kitchen basics**: a good knife, chopping board, kadhai, tawa, pressure cooker, a heavy pan, measuring cups, a sieve; read the recipe first, prepare everything (*mise en place*), taste as you go, clean as you cook.

☐ **COK-25.2 Measures**: cups and spoons, grams; "a pinch", "to taste"; why Indian recipes rely on *andaaz*.

☐ **COK-25.3 A beginner's 20 dishes (in order of difficulty)**: 1 boiled rice, 2 dal tadka, 3 jeera aloo, 4 poha, 5 upma, 6 masala omelette or besan chilla, 7 khichdi, 8 raita and kachumber, 9 roti, 10 bhindi or beans sabzi, 11 chana masala, 12 rajma, 13 pulao, 14 paneer bhurji or egg curry, 15 sambar, 16 dosa from ready batter, 17 a simple chicken or soy curry, 18 pasta with tomato sauce, 19 kheer, 20 a simple biryani.

☐ **COK-25.4 Common mistakes**: crowding the pan, burning garlic, under-salting, adding ground spices to a dry hot pan, rushing the bhuna.

COK-26 Pantries and the festival food calendar

☐ **COK-26.1 A basic Indian pantry**: atta, rice, two or three dals, oil and ghee, salt, turmeric, red chilli, coriander and cumin powders, whole cumin, mustard seeds, hing, garam masala, onions, tomatoes, ginger, garlic, green chilli, curd.

☐ **COK-26.2 Pantries by cuisine**: South Indian (curry leaves, tamarind, urad dal, coconut), Bengali (mustard oil, panch phoron, poppy seeds), Chinese (soy, vinegar, cornflour), Italian (olive oil, pasta, tomatoes, herbs), Mexican (beans, tortillas, cumin, chillies), Thai (fish sauce, coconut milk, lemongrass).

☐ **COK-26.3 Festival food calendar**:

Month (approx.)	Festival	Region	Signature foods
January	Makar Sankranti, Pongal, Lohri, Bihu	All India	Til-gud, khichdi, pongal, undhiyu, pitha, gajak
February or March	Holi	North and West	Gujiya, thandai, puran poli, malpua
March or April	Ugadi, Gudi Padwa, Baisakhi, Navroz	South, West, Punjab, Parsi	Ugadi pachadi (six tastes), shrikhand-puri, kada prasad
Varies (lunar)	Ramzan and Eid ul-Fitr	All India	Haleem, sheer khurma, sevaiyan, iftar dishes
August	Onam, Raksha Bandhan, Janmashtami	Kerala, North	Sadya, ghevar, panjiri, makhan-mishri
August or September	Ganesh Chaturthi	Maharashtra and beyond	Modak
September or October	Navratri, Durga Puja, Dussehra	All India	Fasting foods, bhog khichuri, sandesh
October or November	Diwali, Chhath	All India, Bihar	Mithai, chakli, thekua
December	Christmas	All India, Goa, Kerala	Plum cake, bebinca, kulkuls, appam and stew

COK-27 Cooking with children and on a budget

☐ **COK-27.1 With children**: washing vegetables, rolling rotis, assembling chaat and sandwiches; keep knives and hot oil with adults.

☐ **COK-27.2 On a budget**: dals and millets for protein, seasonal vegetables, cooking in batches, using leftovers (fried rice, roti upma, kheer from leftover rice).

☐ **COK-27.3 Careers**: chef, baker, food scientist, nutritionist, food writer, food photographer, restaurant manager; hotel management institutes (IHM, NCHMCT), and food technology degrees.

PART 13 — REVIEWS AND VOICES

About this Part. Reviews in two forms: what critics said (summarised in our own words, with credit) and Kritikesh's own reviews of dishes, restaurants, cookbooks and street stalls.

COK-28 Critics' Corner: food critics and food media

☐ **COK-28.1 Critics**: Ruth Reichl, Jonathan Gold (the first food critic to win a Pulitzer, 2007), Jay Rayner, Pete Wells, Giles Coren; India's Vir Sanghvi, Rashmi Uday Singh, Marryam Reshii, Rushina Munshaw-Ghildiyal, Kunal Vijayakar.

☐ **COK-28.2 Books on food**: Brillat-Savarin (1825), M. F. K. Fisher, Michael Pollan's *The Omnivore's Dilemma* (2006), Achaya, Collingham's *Curry*, Madhur Jaffrey's *Climbing the Mango Trees* (2005).

☐ **COK-28.3 Shows and media**: *Khana Khazana*, *Highway on My Plate*, *Chef's Table* (2015), *Salt Fat Acid Heat*, *Parts Unknown*, *MasterChef* (India from 2010); food bloggers who credit their sources.

COK-29 The critics said, I say (page template)

1. **The dish, restaurant or book in two lines**: what, where, who, when, price band (dated).
2. **What the critics said**: 3 to 5 named views, summarised in my own words, with links and dates.
3. **Where they agree and disagree**.
4. **What I say**: my own view (link to COK-30).
5. **If you liked this, try next**: three linked dishes, places or books.

COK-30 My Review Desk (Kritikesh's food review template)

☐ **Header**: dish or place, cuisine, city, date of visit, price per person (dated).

☐ **My one-line verdict**.

☐ **Taste**: the six rasas and the five tastes; balance, seasoning, freshness.

☐ **Texture, aroma and look**.

☐ **Authenticity and story**: how close to the home version, and who taught the cook.

☐ **Hygiene, service and value for money**.

☐ **Diet notes**: vegetarian, vegan, Jain options; allergens.

☐ **My rating** on a clear five-point scale, and **tags and try-next links**.

PART 14 — NAVIGATION: TAGS, LINKS AND THE SITE MAP

COK-31 Tag dictionary

☐ **Cuisine**: #indian and each state or community (#rajasthani #bengali #parsi #chettinad #jain), and each country (#japanese #mexican #italian).

☐ **Course**: #breakfast #snack #streetfood #main #rice #bread #dal #curry #soup #salad #sweet #drink #pickle.

☐ **Ingredient**: #rice #wheat #millets #dal #paneer #chicken #fish #egg #vegetables #spices #coconut.

☐ **Technique**: #tadka #bhuna #dum #tandoor #dhungar #steaming #frying #baking #fermentation #pickling.

☐ **Diet**: #vegetarian #vegan #jain #satvik #glutenfree #highprotein #fasting.

☐ **Occasion**: #diwali #holi #eid #onam #pongal #christmas #navratri #wedding #everyday.

☐ **Taste**: #sweet #sour #salty #spicy #bitter #astringent #umami.

☐ **Theme**: #history #science #people #awards #gi #philosophy #psychology #health #sustainability.

☐ **Level**: #beginner #homecook #advanced.

COK-32 Cross-links and the website site map

☐ **COK-32.1 Cross-topic links**: Gardening (kitchen gardens, spices, seasons: GRD); Movies (food films such as *The Lunchbox*, *Ratatouille*: MOV); Books (food writing: BOK); Technology (kitchen technology, food delivery, food science: TEC); Sports (sports nutrition: SPT); the Curriculum Index (Home Science, Biology nutrition, Geography crops, History trade) and the Exam Guide (RPSC/RSSB questions on Rajasthan's food, GI tags and crops).

☐ **COK-32.2 Suggested web addresses**: /cooking/ (home, Gateway), /cooking/did-cooking-make-us-human/<leaf>/ , /cooking/cuisines/<continent>/<country>/ , /cooking/cuisines/india/<state-or-community>/ , /cooking/taste/<topic>/ , /cooking/ingredients/<ingredient>/ , /cooking/spices/<spice>/ , /cooking/techniques/<technique>/ , /cooking/dishes/<family>/<dish>/ , /cooking/history/<era>/ , /cooking/people/<name>/ , /cooking/awards/<award>/<year>/ , /cooking/gi/<product>/ , /cooking/ideas/<topic>/ , /cooking/health/<topic>/ , /cooking/guide/<topic>/ , /cooking/festivals/<festival>/ , /cooking/reviews/<item>/ .

☐ **COK-32.3 Search phrases to own**: "types of Indian cuisine by state", "history of biryani", "how chilli came to India", "what is umami", "six tastes Ayurveda", "GI tag food list India", "World's 50 Best Restaurants 2026", "beginner Indian recipes list", "Jain food rules", with Hindi lines ("bharat ke rajyon ke vyanjan", "dal tadka kaise banaye", "rajasthani khana ke naam").

PART 15 — SOURCES, CREDITS AND EDITOR'S NOTES

COK-S Sources and credits

Knowledge belongs to the people who made it. These are the sources this index stands on; every page on the website will cite its own. Recipes are described in our own words, not copied.

☐ **History and reference**: K. T. Achaya, *Indian Food: A Historical Companion* (1994) and *A Historical Dictionary of Indian Food* (1998); Alan Davidson, *The Oxford Companion to Food* (1999); Harold McGee, *On Food and Cooking* (1984, revised 2004); Colleen Taylor Sen, *Feasts and Fasts* (2015); Lizzie Collingham, *Curry* (2005); Richard Wrangham, *Catching Fire* (2009); Alfred Crosby, *The Columbian Exchange* (1972); Encyclopaedia Britannica.

☐ **India**: FSSAI; ICMR–National Institute of Nutrition, *Dietary Guidelines for Indians* (2024); GI Registry (ipindia.gov.in); Spices Board India; Ministry of Agriculture (millets); Ministry of Tourism.

☐ **World bodies**: FAO; WHO (five keys to safer food, salt and sugar guidance); UNEP Food Waste Index (2024); UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage lists.

☐ **Science**: Ikeda (1908); Julius and colleagues on TRPV1 (1997; Nobel 2021); Billing and Sherman (1998); Ahn and colleagues, *Scientific Reports* (2011); Jain, Rakhi and Bagler, *PLoS ONE* (2015); Kashyap and Weber on Farmana starch grains (2010); Arranz-Otaegui and colleagues on Shubayqa bread (*PNAS*, 2018); Crippa and colleagues, *Nature Food* (2021).

☐ **Latest results checked (13 November 2026)**: the World's 50 Best Restaurants 2026 (Asador Etxebarri, announced in Lima on 4 November; *South China Morning Post*); Bocuse d'Or 2025 (France, Paul Marcon); Michelin Key selection 2026 (47 Indian hotels, press reports); press reports that India has no Michelin restaurant guide yet.

COK-E Editor's notes (corrections and decisions on the brief)

1. **"Curry"** is explained as a European umbrella word, and Indian dish names are used wherever possible.
2. **Dish origin legends** (galouti, sambar, avial, dal baati) are marked as legends.
3. **Rosogolla** is credited to both Odisha and Bengal, as both GI tags stand.
4. **The six rasas and the five tastes** are presented side by side as two systems with different purposes.
5. **MSG** is described with the current scientific consensus, and the "tongue map" myth is corrected.
6. **Health** sections carry a "consult a doctor" note, and Ayurvedic advice is labelled as traditional.
7. **Beef and alcohol** are mentioned factually, with a note that laws differ by state.
8. **The 9-field dish card** is split into two linked tables so it fits a printed page.
9. **Added beyond the brief**: Indian-Chinese, Jewish and diaspora kitchens, the spice trade's violence, food delivery, food waste data, careers, and a beginner's pantry.
10. **Not stated because not verified**: the latest James Beard and Asia's 50 Best winners; they will be added to the website with dates.

COK-T My Cooking Tracker

Use the ☐ boxes across the booklet to tick what you have cooked, tasted or explored. A simple tracker for each Part: Part · Sections · Explored · Date started · Date finished. Keep a cooking diary: date, dish, source, who taught me, what I changed, rating.

Progress tracker

Part	Sections	Explored ☐	Started	Finished
PART 0 — THE INTRODUCTION TWIG: DID COOKING MAKE US	8			

HUMAN?				
PART 1 — THE MASTER MAP OF COOKING	1			
PART 2 — WORLD CUISINES	3			
PART 3 — TASTE, FLAVOUR AND THE SCIENCE OF EATING	2			
PART 4 — INGREDIENTS AND THEIR JOURNEYS	3			
PART 5 — TECHNIQUES	3			
PART 6 — DISH FAMILIES	4			
PART 7 — REGISTERS	3			
PART 8 — HISTORY	1			
PART 9 — PEOPLE, AWARDS AND GUIDES	1			
PART 10 — IDEAS: PHILOSOPHY, PSYCHOLOGY AND SOCIETY	2			
PART 11 — HEALTH AND SAFETY	1			
PART 12 — THE PRACTICAL GUIDE	3			
PART 13 — REVIEWS AND VOICES	3			
PART 14 — NAVIGATION: TAGS, LINKS AND THE SITE MAP	2			
PART 15 — SOURCES, CREDITS AND EDITOR'S NOTES	3			